provide a secure western border and strategic depth against India. Pakistan used Taliban-controlled territory in Afghanistan to run training camps for Deobandi militants fighting in Indian-administered Kashmir. Many of these militants were also fighting alongside the Taliban against the Northern Alliance for control of Afghanistan. When Musharraf gathered together his corps commanders to discuss the American ultimatum, several of them raised serious objections to aligning with the US. They argued that 'dumping the Taliban' would not only have dangerous domestic consequences, but would also send a 'negative message' to the jihadis fighting in Indian-administered Kashmir.[5] Their argument suggested that geopolitical and domestic concerns militated against abandoning the Taliban.

Musharraf countered that the consequences of allying against America overruled these concerns. He claims to have simulated a war game immediately after General Ahmed reported his conversation with Armitage. Even with its nuclear arsenal, there was no way Pakistan could prevail in a military conflict against the United States. Musharraf also argued India would be the major beneficiary of a Pakistani decision to stand by the Taliban since the US would accept help from New Delhi, which had already offered bases for an American counter-attack. An Indo-American alliance could result in Pakistan being declared a terrorist state and enable India to 'gain a golden opportunity with regard to Kashmir.' Musharraf feared this could lead the US to target Pakistan's nuclear arsenal, and he was loathe to lose the deterrent capability the country had achieved vis-à-vis India through its acquisition of nuclear weapons.[6] As Ahmed Rashid wrote, Pakistan's concept of national security at the time rested on three pillars: 'resisting Indian hegemony in the region and promoting the Kashmir cause; protecting and developing the nuclear program; and promoting a pro-Pakistan government in Afghanistan.'[7] Musharraf chose to sacrifice the Taliban in the hopes that doing so would protect the Kashmir jihad and Pakistan's nuclear deterrent. However, this 'sacrifice' was a temporary one. The Musharraf regime provided safe haven and other support to the Taliban after the successful American invasion, which contributed heavily to the latter's ability to mount an insurgency against US and Coalition forces during the ensuring years.